Built to fail

How the home repairs market is failing consumers

citizens advice

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Executive Summary

The home repairs market plays a vital role in ensuring that people can live in safe, comfortable and well-maintained homes. Every year, millions of consumers rely on tradespeople and repair services for urgent fixes, routine maintenance and larger improvement works.

However, for too many people, what should be a straightforward process of maintaining and improving their home becomes a source of stress, financial loss and uncertainty. In 2025 alone, Citizens Advice received around 37,000 complaints related to home maintenance and improvements, making this one of the largest sources of consumer complaints we see. New research, drawn from a sample of over 3,000 UK adults who hired a trader to deliver a home repair or home improvement project in the last 18 months, provides further insight into the challenges that consumers face in this market. Our research found that 28% experienced an issue with their most recent project, and those who had to pay extra lost an average (median) of £750, with one in ten (11%) losing over £5,000.

The consequences of these problems extend beyond financial loss. Consumers reported unsafe homes, prolonged disruption, and significant stress and anxiety when repairs went wrong. When things go wrong, consumers often struggle to resolve issues, with more than one in three (35%) people who took action after experiencing a problem finding it difficult to know where to go for help. Access to Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR) appears to improve outcomes: 86% of issues were resolved where the trader was a member of an ADR scheme, compared to 67% where they were not. However, access to ADR remains inconsistent across the sector, meaning that whether consumers have a clear route to resolution often depends on the individual trader they choose and the protections they happen to offer.

The difficulties consumers experience reflect wider weaknesses in how the market operates. Consumers struggle to identify trustworthy traders, with existing routes such as trader directories, reviews and accreditation schemes failing to provide consistent reassurance. Our research found that carrying out additional checks before hiring a trader did not reduce the likelihood of experiencing a problem, highlighting the limits of relying on consumers to navigate risks in a market where protections are weak. A lack of confidence in the market is also changing how people engage with it: more than a quarter (28%) attempted repairs themselves and 26% delayed or avoided essential work because they did not believe they could find someone they trusted. Problems continue after a trader has been hired. Consumers report difficulties contacting traders and a lack of basic documentation about the work agreed.

These issues are not limited to rogue traders. Poor outcomes are experienced across the market: our survey found that consumers who used a national or regional brand, franchise or installation service from a brand were significantly more likely to experience problems than those who used a sole trader.

At the heart of these issues is a regulatory framework that too often leaves consumers to fend for themselves. Legal protections in the home repairs sector are fragmented and difficult to enforce, voluntary schemes provide inconsistent reassurance, and rogue and poor-performing traders continue operating with limited oversight or accountability. Consumers are not failing to make good choices; rather, the market is failing to provide the information, standards and protections needed for those choices to reliably lead to good outcomes.

That's why we're calling for:

- The expansion of mandatory licensing to more trades as part of the government's agenda to professionalise construction
- Improved access to Alternative Dispute Resolution to provide consumers with a practical route to redress
- A single register for traders, providing a trusted source of information to help consumers make informed decisions
- A stronger enforcement framework with defined responsibilities and better coordination between organisations to tackle rogue traders and improve consumer protection.

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Introduction

In 2025 the home repairs market accounted for 11.8% of all complaints received by the Citizens Advice consumer service. And year on year, home repairs and improvements have consistently been among the top complaints. So what is it about this market that drives such high levels of problems?

First, it's important to understand the way this market is regulated.

A patchwork framework that does not match consumer expectations

The home repairs market is currently regulated through a combination of consumer law, enforcement activity and voluntary schemes, creating a fragmented landscape for consumers and traders. The Consumer Rights Act 2015 provides core protections, including requirements for services to be delivered with reasonable care and skill, while the Digital Markets, Competition and Consumers Act 2024 addresses issues such as unfair trading practices, fake reviews and misleading claims. However, enforcement of these protections relies primarily on local Trading Standards, who operate through intelligence-led approaches to assess risks and target limited resources where they can have the greatest impact. The level of compliance and enforcement activity in the home repairs sector can therefore vary depending on local priorities, available capacity and the harms identified in each area. Other protections, such as those provided through the Consumer Credit Act, have limited reach because a majority of consumers pay for repairs through cash, bank transfer or debit card rather than credit.

Alongside statutory protections, consumers are faced with a wide range of voluntary schemes, accreditations and trader review platforms that aim to provide reassurance about quality and trustworthiness. Participation in Alternative Dispute Resolution, which provides a faster, cheaper way of resolving conflicts and disputes between parties without going to a formal trial or court, is also voluntary. As a result, the level of protection consumers receive often depends on voluntary commitments from individual traders rather than consistent, enforceable standards across the market.

Importantly, this contrasts with consumer perceptions of how the market is regulated, with younger consumers in particular more likely to overestimate the extent of existing protections. More than half (53%) of UK adults responsible for arranging home repairs either wrongly believed that all traders delivering home repair or improvements work have to be licensed or registered with a professional body, or did not know, rising to

83% for those aged 18-34. Similarly, around 1 in 2 (51%) UK adults responsible for arranging home repairs either wrongly believed that traders delivering home repair or improvements work have to be registered with an ombudsman scheme or dispute resolution service or did not know, rising to 77% for the 18-34 demographic.

This gap between consumers' expectations of protection and the protections that are actually available creates a significant risk. If people believe they are better protected than they are, they may make decisions based on a false sense of security, leaving them exposed to financial harm, poor-quality work and limited options when things go wrong.

Moving beyond consumer education

Issues in the home repairs market have been widespread for a long time, but often policymakers have relied on consumer education to reduce harms, rather than tackling the flaws that run through the market. The continuing high levels of detriment, and the gulf between how the market is regulated and consumer expectations, show that this approach just isn't working.

We wanted to explore solutions that could improve outcomes for consumers. To inform our work, we commissioned a large survey, including over 3,000 UK adults who used a trader for a home repair or home improvement project in the last 18 months. Full details can be found in the methodology. We explored their journey through the market, including how they made decisions about the traders they used, all the way through to how they navigated redress. The large sample size also meant we were able to look at the relationships between the actions consumers took, and the experiences they had. We supplemented this research with qualitative interviews with people who have recently hired a trader to deliver home repairs work, and insights from our consumer service data.

In the report that follows, we will explore the full customer journey, showing the prevalence of issues in the market and impact these have, the barriers consumers face when seeking redress, and the shortfall in protections when consumers find and hire traders. This culminates in a series of recommendations for policymakers to address the problems in this market.

Home repair issues and failures

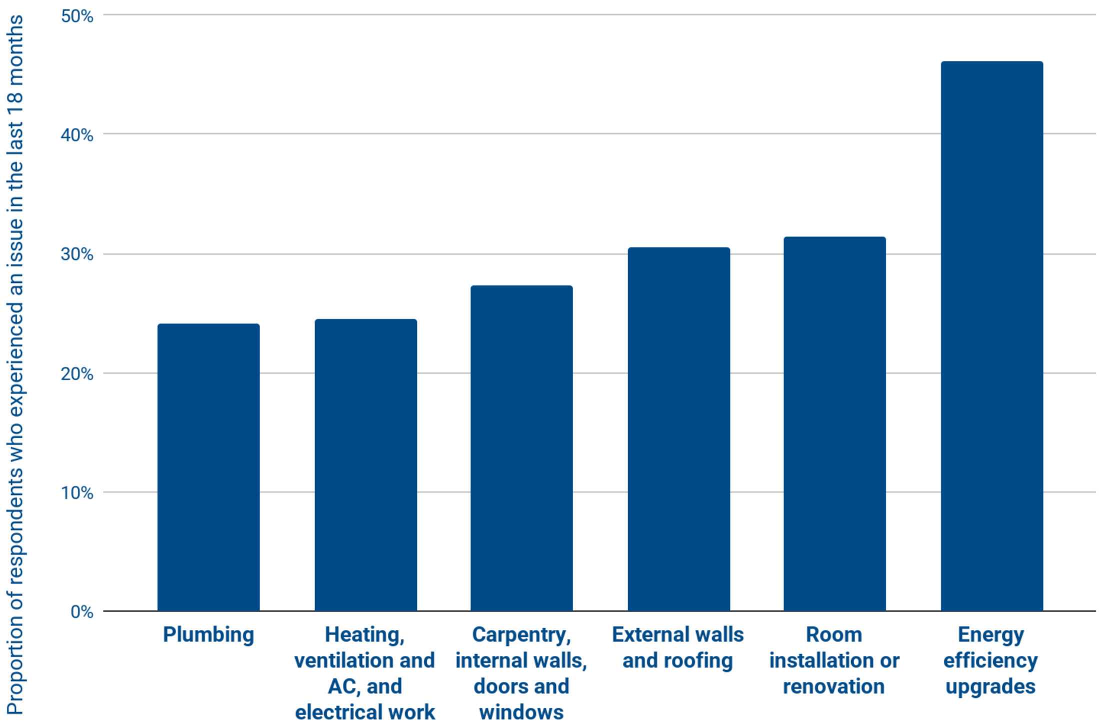
Issues with home repairs are worryingly common. In the last 18 months, over 1 in 4 (28%) UK adults responsible for arranging home repairs experienced an issue with their most recent repair or improvement project. Many have work extending on for months after promises of completion, low quality work causing further damage to their homes, and costs that keep on climbing.

For those who experienced an issue with a trader on their most recent home repair, a variety of problems came up:

- 20% said the work was completed to a poor standard
- 18% said the work didn't fix the problem, or the problem persisted after the work was done
- 16% said there was an issue with the products or materials, for example they were poor quality or didn't work
- 14% said they were charged more than they were quoted without their approval.

As Figure 1 below shows, issues are not isolated to specific trades, highlighting the need for fundamental interventions that span across the market. But the number of consumers who have experienced an issue when making energy efficiency upgrades was markedly higher. In previous reports we have raised the issues in retrofit and energy efficient measures and called for a series of interventions, including a single quality scheme and simple redress.

Figure 1: Proportion of people responsible for home repairs who experienced an issue in last 18 months by project type



Ryan's Story[1]

Ryan arranged for a builder to renovate several rooms in his house, including refurbishing his kitchen, bathrooms and fitting new flooring. He confirmed the price of flooring when the builder ordered it, however Ryan ended up being charged £2,000 more than agreed. Ryan felt there was nothing he could do as he wanted the builders to finish the work, concerned his only other option would be to spend even more money on a new builder. The costs kept rising as the builder ordered too many tiles after not measuring the bathroom correctly. After the flooring was laid, Ryan noticed the floorboards were a lower quality to what he agreed to and were already lifting. Ryan felt ripped off paying spiralling costs for shoddy work.

[1] Names of case studies and quotes have been changed to protect the identity of interview participants and Citizens Advice consumer service clients.

Significant delays are also a common issue and can cause further damage to homes, or leave people with unresolved problems for months on end. One in five (21%) people who experienced a problem with their most recent home repair said the work was substantially delayed. Whilst the uncertainty of unfinished work can cause stress and frustration, in more severe cases it can lead to health problems and safety concerns. This was the case for Priya who faced delays to work to fix a leaking roof:

> *I understand the rain being a major issue. You can't get on roofs. But just some idea of timescale or some acknowledgement of that I'm literally lying under black mould now. And I've got a long-term respiratory condition. So that for me was really quite frightening.*
>
> - Priya

Consumers face emotional, financial and safety impacts

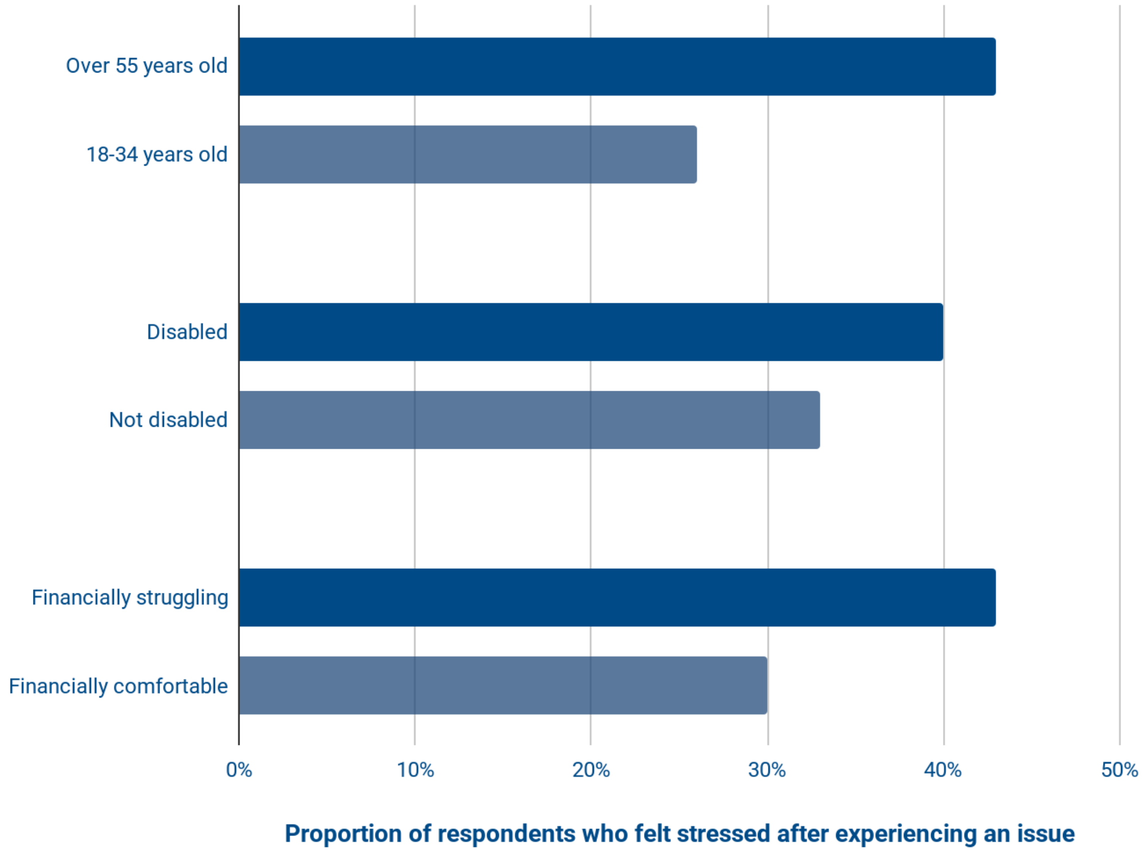
Initial issues with traders or their work can snowball, causing daily impacts to people's home life, health implications and high levels of stress.

Over 1 in 3 (34%) people who experienced an issue with their most recent home repair trader said it made them feel stressed. The concern about further damage from ongoing issues, and having to figure out how to resolve the problem before it gets worse takes a toll. Amin's story highlights the emotional impact of these interactions:

> *As well constantly monitoring if there's like— especially if there's rainfall, so is the water dripping, is the radiator still dripping, these sort of questions...you just create a sort of paranoia in a way and an anxiety.*
>
> - Amin

These impacts are not felt equally by everyone, Figure 2 shows that some groups were more likely to feel stress from issues with the work on their home.

Figure 2: Proportion of people who felt stressed after experiencing an issue with their trader in the last 18 months, by demographic group



Concerningly, over 1 in 10 (12%) people who experienced an issue with their most recent home repair trader said it made them feel unsafe. This was echoed in the interviews, where respondents reported being worried about unresolved structural damage which could put their home and family at risk. For Alex, this translated into a constant sense of worry:

> *Constantly having to keep an eye on things all the time and…worrying about if anything happened, if there was an underlying thing that could cause the floor to fall through because it was leaking.*
>
> \- Alex

For other respondents like Femi, safety worries also included feeling uncomfortable with the trader knowing personal details:

They know where you live, they've been on your roof, they know what your house looks like. I'm wary of like, he could just come round and start abusing us or do something to the house or something like that. So I'm quite worried about it.

- Femi

The financial impact of home repairs gone wrong

Home repairs and improvements are often one of the most expensive investments people make. After months, or sometimes years of saving, having to pay additional costs for fix or redo work can have a knock-on impact on household budgets. For those who experienced an issue with the most recent work on their home, 22% had to pay more than they expected or had budgeted for, and 19% had to pay extra to redo work that had been delivered to a poor standard.

It just kept mounting, kept mounting... I expect a professional builder tradespeople when they're given a budget, that they work within that budget.

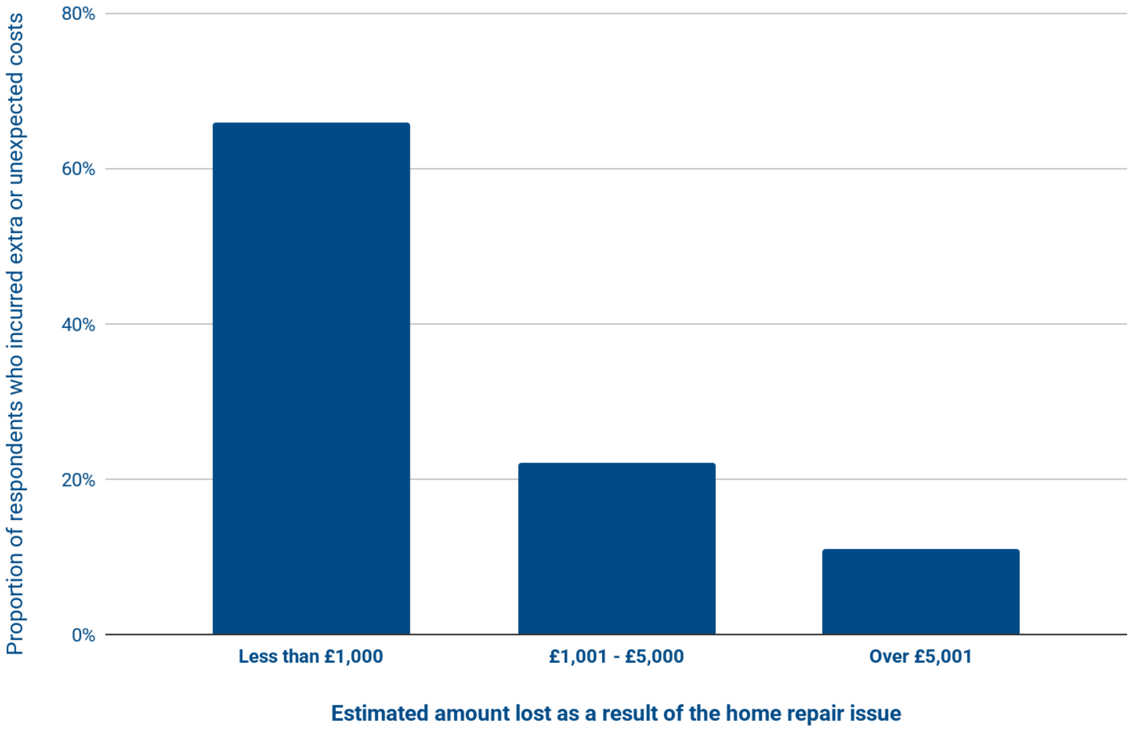
- Greg

For this group who had to pay for further costs or more than expected, the average (median) amount lost was £750. However, as Figure 3 (overleaf) shows: for some people extra costs extended into the thousands.

Unanticipated costs can have a detrimental impact on household budgets, leading to people cutting back in other parts of life to make sure their home is liveable. Where people had to pay extra or more than expected because of the issue with work on their home, almost 2 in 5 (38%) had to cut back on other essential costs, such as how much heating they used or groceries. In addition:

- 21% had to borrow money to finish the work
- 19% were unable to pay other essential bills
- 12% couldn't afford to finish the work or pay the balance.

Figure 3: Proportion of people responsible for home repairs who had extra costs following an issue with their trader in the last 18 months by estimated amount personally lost



Significant safety concerns and daily disruptions

For those who experienced an issue with the most recent work on their home:

- 11% said it made their home unsafe, such as structural damage or a sewerage leak
- 10% were left without essential services, such as a way to wash or heat the home
- 9% had to live somewhere else temporarily or permanently.

Whilst these more severe impacts are less common than the emotional and financial implications, it can have a lasting impact on a household's daily life.

Sam's story

Sam arranged for a trader to fix subsidence in their kitchen, which was quoted to take 6 weeks. The work still wasn't finished 7 months later. As the trader had left the work unattended, the kitchen was impacted with water damage which led to mould developing. Sam had their elderly parents living with them, so the mould became more of a worry. The damage became so extensive that the house was condemned. The trader had offered to pay for alternative accommodation but later refused to reimburse Sam.

Barriers to redress

Issues from home repair and improvement projects can cause daily disruptions to people's everyday lives. This means that quick and effective resolutions are front and centre to consumers' needs. In practice, consumers often struggle to get issues resolved quickly or effectively. There is low awareness and inconsistent provision of Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR) schemes, limited recourse through the Consumer Rights Act, and variable enforcement of consumer law. In addition, over 1 in 3 (35%) consumers who took action after experiencing an issue with their trader found it difficult to know where to go for help.

> *With builders, there's not really any way of logging a complaint, if you see what I mean, apart from going directly to the builder who might just say go away, and ignore you.*
>
> \- Olivia

Almost 1 in 5 (18%) people who experienced an issue didn't take any action to resolve the issue. Whilst a portion of this group didn't think the issue was serious enough to escalate, 15% did not want to confront the trader, and 13% did not know what they could do.

Furthermore, our research found 82% of people who took action said they experienced barriers when trying to resolve their issue. For this group, the most common barriers were:

- 20% said the process took a long time
- 16% said the trader ignored them
- 15% said they did not know how to escalate the issue beyond the trader
- 15% said the process was complicated or difficult.

Consumers are forced to advocate for their rights when things go wrong

When trying to resolve issues with traders, consumers are often faced with challenging conversations, confrontation and denial of wrong-doing. Consumers feel they have to tread carefully when raising an issue with their trader, worried that the trader wouldn't prioritise them or ignore them completely.

> *I want nothing to do with him now. I don't want him in my house.*
>
> \- Aisha

Access to alternative dispute resolution is limited

When consumers are unable to reach a resolution with a trader, ADR can help the two parties come to agreement or make a decision about the complaint. However, as ADR is voluntary, it is not universally available or well known by consumers.

> *I know they exist for other things because I've used them for gas, for utilities, but I didn't know that they existed for home repairs.*
>
> \- Greg

While it is not known how many traders are registered with an ADR provider, evidence suggests that uptake is limited, with a survey of 200 UK contractors commissioned by DisputeAssist in 2023 finding that 42% of contractors surveyed were not part of an ADR scheme.

Consumers who use traders registered with an ADR scheme have more success resolving their issue. 86% of people who used a trader who was a member of an ADR scheme said their issue was resolved after taking action, compared to 67% of people whose trader was not a member.

The absence of widely available and accessible ADR contributes to the confusion around where consumers can access redress, and seek help when their attempts to resolve a dispute with a trader fail. This leaves consumers with few options to escalate their issues elsewhere, and potentially missing out on their chances to resolve disputes.

Systemic challenges in the home repairs market

So far, we've shown the harms consumers experience when home repairs go wrong, from poor-quality work and unexpected costs to lengthy disputes and difficulties putting things right. The next question is why these problems persist despite consumers trying to make informed choices. The answer lies beyond individual decisions. While consumer detriment is common and many people face significant barriers to putting things right when home repairs go wrong, these problems are symptoms of wider failures in the market. Difficulties finding and hiring trustworthy traders, alongside the continued presence of rogue operators, create the conditions in which poor outcomes are able to persist. Consumers are not failing to make good choices; rather, the market is failing to provide the information, standards and protections needed for those choices to reliably lead to good outcomes.

Jen's story shows how problems can occur at all stages of the consumer journey, with Jen facing unrelenting challenges and insufficient protections which left her losing trust in the market.

Jen's story

Jen owns her home with her husband. Last winter she noticed **water damage** in her bedroom, coming from a **leak in the roof**.

1 **Finding traders**
Jen used **search engines, social media and recommendation sites** to find a trader. Although she was **worried that good reviews weren't legitimate**. She was **unsure whether traders' accreditations would give assurance** of good work.

2 **Hiring traders**
Facing upcoming wet weather, Jen and her husband **called a few traders to provide quotes**, and hired the **first available roofer**.

3 **Home repair issues and failures**
Weeks after the work was complete, Jen **noticed the water damage wasn't getting better**. As she thought the roof was fixed, she bought dehumidifiers to dry out the water. She later realised the water damage was getting worse - **something wasn't right**.

4 **Barriers to redress**
Jen **contacted the trader** explaining the problem, but **the trader became angry,** denying wrongdoing. She was put off by the trader and **wasn't aware of ADR schemes**.

5 Jen got a second opinion, having to **start the process again to find another trader**. The second trader assessed the roof and **couldn't see evidence of the work** that the first trader had committed to doing.

6 Jen recontacted the first trader who said he could come back for an **additional fee**. As his work had caused problems, **she didn't want to re-hire him**.

7 Jen hired the second trader to successfully fix the leak, and a surveyor confirmed the new work was high quality, though the original damage remained.

8 Jen **considered court action but was concerned about the cost** and how to prove that work was completed to a poor standard. As Jen had **paid via bank transfer, she could not access any credit protections.**

9 **Detriment**
Jen **used up her savings, borrowed money from family and cancelled a holiday** to cover the costs of redoing the work. Jen was **stressed from the uncertainty** of structural damage and seeing the leak get worse day by day.

10 **Future outlook**
Jen's trust in the market is broken. Moving forward, she plans to **rely on DIY,** and **personal recommendations to find traders** if she has no other option.

*"It feels like everybody's lying to us. **We can't trust anybody**. We don't. And it made me really frustrated that I don't know what roofing is and I'm not an electrician and I'm not a plumber...I have to trust somebody else, and I've just lost that."*

Finding traders

Low confidence shapes engagement with the market

A key theme from our research is the difficulty that consumers have in finding trustworthy traders to take on home repairs work for them. Overall, 42% of people responsible for arranging home repairs said they thought it was difficult to find a trader, compared with 37% who said they thought it was easy. However, confidence dropped significantly when asked specifically about finding a trader they trusted to deliver good-quality work: 55% said they thought this was difficult, while only 27% thought it was easy.

This lack of confidence in the market not only leaves consumers vulnerable to poor outcomes by discouraging people from seeking essential maintenance, but can also result in worse outcomes when they do engage with the market. A number of our interviews highlighted that consumers facing time pressure, due to urgently needed repairs, often took shortcuts when it came to finding traders. This included choosing the first available trader, and trusting surface level signals such as professional looking profiles. Consumers often acknowledged these shortcuts as a consequence of limited options rather than a reliable way to assess quality.

> *I think there's clearly an ongoing financial problem with...the stress of it. I don't want any more contractors in the house...we've probably got a list of things that we'd want to do, and I just don't want to. I have sort of lost trust.*
>
> \- Louise

Consumers fall back on informal routes when formal routes fail to provide assurance

Consumers often combine a range of methods to find traders. One key frustration identified by multiple consumers in our interviews was the need to cross check multiple sources of information on traders, including recommendation sites, reviews, Companies House, trade bodies and personal recommendations.

Despite this, personal recommendations or having used the trader before remain the most common way of finding a trader. For people who have used a trader in the last 18 months:

- 36% used a referral from someone they knew
- 27% used a trader they had previously hired
- 16% used a trader recommendation site such as Checkatrade or TrustATrader
- 11% used social media
- 7% used an approved or accredited trader scheme, such as local authority approved schemes or Buy With Confidence.

Personal recommendations are valued because they provide a form of evidence that consumers can verify themselves. Interviews showed that recommendations from friends, family or people in their local community feel more reliable because consumers can see examples of completed work and judge the quality for themselves.

> *Friends and family's recommendations are always far weightier. I can go and have a look at their fixed roof and think, is it a good job?*
>
> \- Mo

In contrast, consumers were often sceptical of online trader recommendation sites. Participants raised concerns about whether reviews could be trusted, whether paid listings influenced which traders appeared most prominently, and whether these platforms provided a genuine indication of competence. These concerns remain despite regulatory efforts to improve transparency and vetting on online platforms, suggesting that existing measures have not yet translated into meaningful consumer confidence.

Approved and accredited trader schemes were often underused. When we asked consumers which recommendation sites they had heard of or used, awareness was much lower for government and Trading Standards-backed schemes. Only 24% of people responsible for home repairs had heard of or used the Buy with Confidence Scheme and 40% had heard of or used TrustMark. In contrast, awareness was much higher for commercial marketplace platforms, with 87% having heard of or used CheckATrade or MyBuilder.

Consumers struggle to establish confidence in traders

When consumers attempt to verify traders themselves, they often rely on recommendations or appearances rather than formal assurances. When assessing traders, only 10% of people who had hired a trader in the last 18 months checked the trader’s qualifications, while just 8% checked whether the trader belonged to a professional or trade body. Interviews suggested that some consumers were unclear what accreditations meant in practice or saw them as a 'tick box' exercise.

> *I could remember seeing things, people saying they were members of certain things. But at risk of sounding ignorant to it, I don't really know what they are or what it entails for them to become part of that. They could probably just pay a fee and become that.*
>
> - James

In contrast, consumers who had hired a trader in the last 18 months were far more likely to meet with a trader (31%), check the trader's reviews (29%) or get quotes from several traders (23%). This reflects consumer's attempts to establish trust in the absence of formal signals, often by using proxies which consumers themselves acknowledged as imperfect. This included judging traders based on their responsiveness, tone, punctuality, or overall professionalism. Consumers also relied on online reviews, despite widespread perception that reviews can be unreliable or easily manipulated, again despite new provisions under the Digital Markets, Competition and Consumers Act (DMCCA) which aimed at addressing these concerns. Others, without the technical knowledge to challenge traders, simply relied on 'gut feeling'.

Consumers are not failing to make informed choices; the market is failing to provide them with reliable information to make those choices.

Consumers face issues despite their best efforts to choose quality traders

Our research shows that consumers cannot reliably avoid problems through the choices they make when selecting a trader. Poor outcomes are not limited to rogue traders, and existing indicators of quality do not consistently provide the reassurance consumers expect.

Consumers are more likely to experience an issue when using a brand or business, compared to a sole trader. 20% of people who used an individual sole trader for their most recent home repair experienced an issue. Compared to:

- 54% of people who used a national or regional brand/franchise
- 45% of people who used an installation service from a brand
- 28% of people who used a local business.

It is important to note that respondents who used sole traders were more likely to have carried out lower-cost projects. Three quarters (75%) of people who used a sole trader for their most recent home repair spent under £2,000, compared to 54% of people who used a brand or business. However, consumers may expect that using a larger company would provide more assurance of high quality work. This assumption was a common theme identified in interviews:

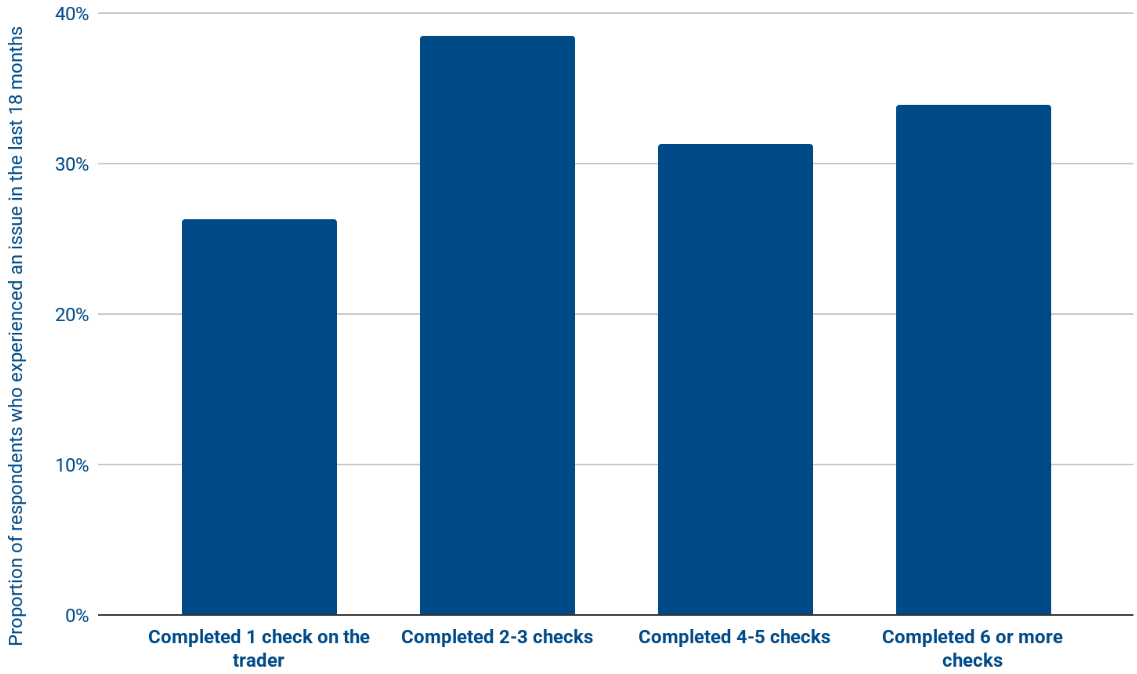
> *Bigger companies where you pay more money, they understand reputation and doing a good job and, you know, making sure everything's done well.*
>
> - Alex

However, the high chance of experiencing an issue with larger, more established traders, especially on more costly projects shows that poor practice is widespread throughout the market rather than confined to rogue traders.

Additionally, using traders who were registered with an accreditation scheme did not reduce the chance of experiencing a problem: 53% of people who used an approved, accredited or registered trader for their most recent home repair experienced an issue. But over half (56%) of people who used an accredited trader for their most recent home repair said they found it easy to work out where to go for help after experiencing an issue, compared to 37% of all people who took action after experiencing an issue. This shows that using an accredited trader makes a difference when trying to resolve a problem.

We also found that there was no meaningful relationship between the checks consumers took before hiring a trader and whether they went on to experience a problem. Checks could include meeting with the trader before hiring them, checking the trader’s reviews and getting quotes from several traders. Figure 6 shows that people who completed only 1 check before choosing their most recent trader were less likely to experience an issue than people who did 6 or more checks. This highlights the limits of relying on consumer education and awareness in a market where protections are weak and there is limited control over who can operate as a trader in the first place.

Figure 4: Proportion of people who experienced an issue with their trader in the last 18 months by number of checks completed on the trader before hiring



Hiring traders

Consumers hire traders expecting the required technical and professional knowledge to complete work on their home to a high standard. However, consumers face challenges when engaging with traders after finding someone suitable, from a lack of necessary documentation to a lack of payment protection. Not only does this add additional effort and stress for consumers, it can leave them with limited means to challenge problems later down the line.

Basic paperwork isn't always provided

Over half (54%) of people who had arranged home repairs in the last 18 months received an invoice or receipt from their trader. This lack of basic paperwork for many consumers can become a problem if an issue occurs and evidence is needed to prove agreed project costs. This does not drastically change for projects of higher value, where in the last 18 months, 51% of consumers whose projects cost under £1,000 received an invoice or receipt from their trader, compared to 54% of consumers whose projects cost over £10,001. Regardless of the cost of a project, all consumers should expect to receive the basic documentation at a minimum.

Traders providing other forms of documentation is also not standard practice:

- 41% of consumers received a written quote
- 41% of consumers received full contact details for the trader
- 27% received a warranty or guarantee
- 18% received a written contract for work on their home.

This varied according to the type of trader used, with approved, accredited or registered traders more likely to provide consumers with documentation.

Figure 5: Type of documentation provided by trader type

Type of documentation provided to consumer	Approved, accredited or registered traders	Traders registered with recommendation sites	Trader not registered with any scheme
A warranty or guarantee for the work	39%	34%	16%
A written contract for the work	30%	23%	9%
Information from the trader on how to raise a concern or make a complain	22%	14%	3%

While approved, accredited and registered traders were consistently more likely to provide consumers with key documentation, provision remained far from universal. This suggests that existing schemes can help raise standards, but they are not currently sufficient to make sure consumers consistently receive the basic information they need. This lack of documentation can make it harder for consumers to know and enforce their rights.

Gaps in payment protection leave consumers exposed to risk

Payment method plays an important role in determining the protections available to consumers if something goes wrong. However, almost two-thirds (63%) of consumers who had hired a trader in the last 18 months paid for home repairs using methods such as cash, cheque or bank transfer, which offer fewer built-in safeguards. While credit and debit card payments can provide routes to redress through mechanisms such as

Section 75 protection or chargebacks, high project costs and credit limits mean many consumers are unable to use these options, and some traders do not accept card payments at all. As a result, the majority of consumers are left relying on more limited forms of protection if issues arise, reinforcing the importance of effective regulation and accessible redress mechanisms in the sector.

Rogue traders continue to drive harm and low confidence

While our findings suggest that the home repairs market's problems run far deeper than the presence of rogue traders, the continued existence of rogue traders operating in the market remains a key driver of harm and low consumer confidence. In 2025, 5,200 people complained to the Citizens Advice consumer service with suspected scams in home repairs and improvements. This has increased by 28% from the same period in 2022. Concerningly, the proportion of scams we see across all home repairs complaints has also increased. In 2022, suspected scams made up 8% of all home repairs and improvements complaints, but this has jumped to 14% in 2025.

These problems are also felt across the UK more broadly. Our survey respondents said that in the last 18 months, they or someone they know had experienced the following:

- Nearly one in 10 (9%) said the final cost was significantly higher than the agreed quote without a valid reason
- Nearly one in 10 (9%) said the work was completed to a poor standard and the trader required more money to fix it
- 7% felt pressured to agree for the trader to do work
- 7% said a trader claimed there was a problem to fix, but they, or someone they know, later found out the problem didn't exist.

Tina's story

Tina found a trader online to repair her leaking chimney. The trader quoted £1,200, which Tina agreed to. The trader later told Tina that further work was needed, which would cost an extra £750. As Tina didn't have the money for the additional work, she refused. Shortly after the trader told Tina the work was complete, Tina noticed the leak wasn't fixed. It turned out the trader fixed the wrong chimney, and to a lower standard of work than agreed. Despite this, the trader continuously called and texted Tina demanding payment, and refused to take the scaffolding down until she paid.

These interactions can leave people shaken, out of pocket and with ongoing problems with their homes. The continued presence of rogue traders in the home repairs market points to a number of structural issues in the market, namely the lack of an established gateway into the market to prevent unqualified traders entering the market, the failure of existing systems of voluntary accreditation to provide clear and consistent signals to consumers, and inconsistent enforcement at the local level.

There is a clear public demand for more action on rogue traders. Our survey found that:

- 40% of people responsible for arranging home repairs said the UK government and industry regulators are not effective at protecting consumers from rogue traders and poor-quality work in the home repair market
- 58% said they would like the government or regulator to take more action to prosecute rogue traders.

Any policy intervention aimed at rebuilding consumer confidence in the home repairs market will need to prioritise strong, visible, and consistent enforcement against rogue traders, because their continued presence is a primary driver of harm and mistrust. When consumers experience or hear about cases of inflated costs, poor-quality workmanship, or coercive behaviour, confidence in the entire market is undermined, even if most traders operate legitimately.

Conclusions and recommendations

The home repairs market is an essential service that millions of households rely on every year. While many consumers receive good outcomes, our research shows that far too many are left exposed to poor workmanship, unexpected costs, lengthy delays, unresolved disputes and, in the most serious cases, unsafe living conditions. More than one in four (28%) people responsible for arranging home repairs experienced a problem with their most recent home repair project, while widespread concerns about trustworthiness are causing many people to delay essential maintenance or attempt repairs themselves.

These problems are not simply the result of individual bad actors. They reflect structural weaknesses in the way the market operates and is regulated. Consumers are expected to navigate a fragmented landscape of accreditation schemes and limited protections without the technical knowledge needed to assess the quality of work or challenge poor practice. When things go wrong, many struggle to identify where to turn for help, and access to effective redress remains limited.

The consequences extend beyond individual disputes. Poor experiences erode trust in the market as a whole, discourage investment in home maintenance and improvements, and create unfair competition for the many skilled and reputable traders who deliver high-quality work. Rogue and poor-performing traders continue to exploit gaps in oversight and enforcement, undermining consumer confidence and damaging the reputation of the sector.

Addressing these issues will require reform to improve standards, strengthen accountability and rebuild consumer confidence in the market. This means moving beyond relying on consumers to navigate risk themselves, and creating a system where trustworthy traders are easier to identify, poor practice is challenged, and consumers have clear routes to protection and redress when things go wrong.

That’s why we’re calling for:

- The expansion of mandatory licensing to more trades as part of the government’s agenda to professionalise construction
- Improved access to alternative dispute resolution to provide consumers with a practicable route to redress

- A single register for traders, to provide a single accessible source of information to enable consumers to make informed decisions
- A clear enforcement framework.

Below we provide further detail on each of these recommendations.

Mandatory licensing

As part of its response to the Phase 2 report of the Grenfell Inquiry, the government is consulting on the creation of a Single Construction Regulator to strengthen oversight of the construction sector, as well as mandatory accreditation for fire engineers and a licensing regime for principal contractors working on higher-risk buildings. While these proposals are welcome, there is a strong case for extending licensing requirements to a wider range of trades operating in consumers' homes.

Introducing mandatory licensing for traders could provide a crucial policy lever to establish and maintain binding standards of competence, professionalism and consumer protection across the home repairs market. It should harness existing expertise and infrastructure, for example through a hub-and-spoke model in which a single construction regulator sets standards and provides oversight, while approved scheme providers act as the route through which traders obtain and maintain accreditation and standards of professionalism and consumer protection are enforced.

But licensing is not a silver bullet. To be effective, any licensing regime must fulfill three key criteria:

1. Send strong signals to consumers

A licensing framework should provide consumers with a clear signal that a trader has met established standards. This would provide assurance to consumers, while also reducing the burden on consumers to navigate a complex landscape of schemes and accreditations.

2. Reflect genuine compliance with standards

For licensing to command consumer confidence, it must be a meaningful indicator of ongoing compliance with standards of competence, professionalism and consumer protection. While any future regulatory approach should work with existing accreditation infrastructure, it is important that it does not simply formalise these structures, as our research suggests that existing accreditation schemes do not consistently deliver better outcomes for consumers.

A future licensing regime should therefore establish a clear framework for how existing scheme providers operate within a licensing model. Under a hub and spoke model, the regulator should establish clear expectations for scheme providers, including standards for accreditation, monitoring, consumer protection and disciplinary action, and should have the capacity to work flexibly and tighten standards where the market is not delivering.

3. Provide fair value for consumers

Since the additional costs of new licensing schemes will be borne by consumers, the government needs to carefully assess the costs and benefits of any new regulatory framework to ensure that it delivers clear value for consumers. However, the costs of licensing should not be considered in isolation. They must be weighed against the costs consumers already bear in a market where poor outcomes are common and protections are weak. There is also evidence that consumers already recognise the value of stronger safeguards: research by the Federation of Master Builders and HomeOwners Alliance found that more than 80% of homeowners would be willing to pay more to hire a licensed builder.

A single register for traders

Our research shows that a lack of basic information about traders is a significant source of consumer uncertainty in the home repairs market and can often undermine attempts to seek redress when problems arise. Consumers are currently required to navigate a fragmented landscape of websites, accreditation schemes and review platforms to gather information about traders. Even when information is available, it can be difficult to verify, interpret or compare, leaving consumers without a clear and reliable basis on which to make decisions about who they invite into their homes.

A single register for traders would address this information gap by providing a trusted, centralised source of verified information. The register should include key details such as traders' names, contact information and ADR membership, as well as combining information from the regulator, accreditation providers and Trading Standards, such as accreditations and information about enforcement action.

To maximise its impact, the register should be embedded into the consumer journey. Government should work with online marketplaces, comparison websites, accreditation schemes and consumer advice providers to ensure that information from the register is available wherever consumers search for traders. This could include the development of APIs that allow verified registration and accreditation data to be displayed directly on third-party platforms, reducing the need for consumers to cross-check multiple sources and helping trusted information become the default point of reference in the market.

Widening access to Alternative Dispute Resolution

Our research suggests that access to Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR) can play an important role in improving outcomes for consumers when problems arise. Consumers who have access to ADR benefit from a clearer route to redress, while the existence of an independent dispute resolution mechanism can also act as a deterrent against poor-quality work and poor business practices.

Sectors such as energy, financial services, legal services, and estate agencies require access to independent dispute resolution because consumers often lack the technical expertise to assess service quality, disputes can involve significant sums, and court action is often disproportionate or difficult to access. The home repairs market has similar characteristics, with consumers relying on traders for complex and important work affecting safety, property value, and living conditions. A mandatory ADR requirement, would give consumers a faster and more accessible route to remedy, improve confidence in the sector, and prevent poor traders gaining an advantage by avoiding accountability. Making ADR mandatory across the home repairs and improvements sector would address the current patchwork of provision, improve consumer awareness, and ensure that consumers have access to a practical means of resolving disputes without resorting to court action. It would complement, rather than replace, Trading Standards enforcement by providing a structured mechanism for resolving individual disputes while generating intelligence on wider market problems.

A clear enforcement framework

Rogue traders remain a significant source of harm in the home repairs market, delivering substandard work, defrauding consumers and contributing to wider distrust in the sector. While the problems in the market extend beyond rogue traders, tackling those who deliberately exploit consumers must remain a key priority. A clearer regulatory framework should establish where responsibility sits across enforcement, redress and quality assurance, helping consumers and traders understand which organisations are responsible for addressing different types of problems.

From the consumer perspective, a proportionately resourced Trading Standards should have a clearer role in tackling breaches of consumer law, unlawful practices and cases where there is a wider risk of public harm. The recommendations above also play a role in creating an effective deterrent to rogue traders and to promote better consumer outcomes. Issues that do not require Trading Standards or could be addressed earlier, such as disputes over workmanship, would be addressed through alternative routes including Alternative Dispute Resolution and the supervisory role of scheme providers. If licensing works effectively, the possibility of a licence being revoked should act as a credible deterrent. The government should work closely with Trading Standards to define this role further and identify the most effective mechanisms, including the resources and coordination needed, to deliver stronger enforcement and better protection for consumers.

Appendix 1: Methodology

The data in this report is drawn from research by Opinium commissioned by Citizens Advice. The research combined a nationally representative online survey with 5,000 UK adults responsible for the home repairs and improvements in their home. All respondents were asked a set of questions on their perceptions of the home repairs market and potential policy solutions. From the survey respondents, we derived a weighted subsample of 3,438 individuals who reported using a trader for home repairs or improvements within the previous 18 months. This subgroup was then asked a set of questions relating to their experiences with traders.

Opinium also conducted a programme of qualitative interviews to explore experiences in depth. This included 20 one-hour indepth interviews, alongside four in-home interviews and two interviews conducted in the participants' preferred language, enabling a richer understanding of lived experiences. The qualitative research explored how issues unfold, how customers respond, and their attitudes towards potential solutions, while the survey quantified the scale and prevalence of these experiences across the UK population. The research was conducted in February and March 2026. Interview participants' quotes and case studies have been de-identified and pseudonymised.

The research is also informed by data from the Citizens Advice consumer service, using case notes and the number of people we helped with home maintenance and improvements complaints. Some case studies were identified through case note data, case studies have been de-identified and pseudonymised to protect the identity of clients.

Appendix 2: Current regulation

The UK home repairs market is currently regulated via a combination of crosscutting consumer law and a variety of voluntary schemes and accreditations.

Consumer law

Consumer Rights Act (2015)

The Consumer Rights Act (CRA) provides the main consumer protections for the home repairs market, setting out the statutory rights relating to consumer contracts, provisions relating to unfair terms in consumer contracts as well as investigatory powers for enforcement agencies. Under the terms of the CRA, traders must perform services with reasonable care and skill and (where a price is not contractually agreed in advance) at a reasonable price. It also gives consumers the right to ask for a repeat performance of the service, or, when that is not possible, the right to ask for a price reduction. Consumers also have the right to ask for a price reduction if there has been repeat performance, and it hasn't resolved the issue, or if the trader can’t carry out the repeat performance within a reasonable time and without significant inconvenience to the consumer.

Digital Markets, Competition and Consumers Act (2024)

The DMCCA sets out a range of provisions relating to unfair trading practices. These include fake reviews, misuse of trust marks, pressure selling and selling illegal products. The Competition and Markets Authority (CMA) has direct enforcement powers in consumer protection law under part 3 of the DMCCA. The CMA has also published guidance for online platforms that recommend traders to consumers to ensure that they comply with the DMCCA, for example by making sure that claims about traders are clear and accurate, and that online platforms have satisfactory vetting processes. Local authority Trading Standards may also apply to the court for an enforcement order if they consider that a person has engaged in a commercial practice which constitutes an infringement of the DMCCA.

Consumer Credit Act (1974)

Section 75 of the CCA provides legal protection for credit purchases of more than £100 and up to £30,000, allowing consumers to claim back from the creditor in scenarios such as faulty goods, non-delivery or trader insolvency. Section 56 of the CCA ensures that, when credit is arranged through a third party such as a trader, lenders cannot disclaim responsibility for what these third parties say or do.

However, the protection afforded by the CCA is limited in the home repairs market because the majority of transactions in the market are not paid for by credit. In our survey 63% of consumers paid for their most recent home repair via cash, cheque or bank transfer, while a further 20% paid via debit card.

Enforcement of consumer law

In the home repairs market, the CRA and DMCCA are enforced primarily by local authorities' Trading Standards. However, local Trading Standards face significant resourcing challenges as well as competing local priorities, and as a result outcomes for consumers making complaints to trading standards depends heavily on where the complaint is made.

Voluntary schemes and Alternative Dispute Resolution

Consumer law in the home repairs industry is supplemented by a range of voluntary schemes and accreditations, which aim to provide consumers with assurances around the quality of service they will receive from their trader. They are provided by a range of bodies, including government backed organisations, trade associations, online marketplaces and consumer advocates.

Some voluntary schemes also provide access to ADR services, although individual traders can work with ADR providers independently. While not all forms of ADR are legally binding, ADR can provide a cheaper, more accessible alternative to legal proceedings for consumers. Beginning in April 2026, provisions in the DMCCA revised the framework for ADR by requiring ADR providers to be accredited and overseen by the Chartered Trading Standards Institute, and strengthening obligations for businesses to inform consumers of their right to ADR.

However, in contrast to regulated sectors such as energy or financial services, where ADR services are mandatory and provided by a single organisation in the form of an Ombudsman, provision of ADR in the home repairs market is fragmented and voluntary. This means that there are significant gaps in ADR provision throughout the market, and consumer awareness of ADR remains low.

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